

# Exploring Anxiety

## discussion questions

1

Imagine that someone waved a magic wand, and you no longer experienced *any* anxiety. What would change about your life? What would be the downsides to being unable to feel any anxiety?

2

Everyone experiences anxiety in a unique way. Physical symptoms are common, such as muscle tension, upset stomach, racing heart, or sweaty palms. Mental aspects such as ruminating or catastrophizing are another feature of anxiety. How do you typically experience anxiety on both a physical and mental level?

3

Since anxiety is an inevitable part of life, we have to learn how to cope with it. Some ways of doing this are healthy, such as exercising, spending time with others, and meditating. Others are unhealthy, such as using substances or withdrawing from the world. What are some healthy ways you cope with anxiety? When do you use unhealthy coping strategies?

4

There's no shortage of things to worry about. Some people get anxious about family or relationship issues. Others worry a lot about their appearance, health, or finances. Politics or world events are also common sources of anxiety. What do you tend to worry about? Describe some of the triggers for your anxiety.

5

Your mindset about anxiety determines how it affects you. If you see anxiety as a chance to learn and grow, it can be a positive force in your life. On the other hand, if you see anxiety as only a burden, it's more likely to have a negative impact. What's your mindset about your anxiety? How might you change this mindset to improve your relationship with anxiety?

6

Big life decisions can cause a lot of anxiety. You may be afraid of making a mistake, overwhelmed by others' advice, or unsure of what you really want. How does anxiety affect your decision-making? What ways have you found to reduce or manage this anxiety?

7

It's common to avoid what you're anxious about. This might take the form of retreating from anxiety-provoking situations, delaying decisions, or repressing emotions. How do you use avoidance to manage your anxiety? What are the pros and cons of this approach?

8

Anxiety can reveal what matters most to a person. For example, someone who worries a lot about illness probably really values health. Someone who stresses over finances probably wants security. Reflect on the common themes of your anxiety. What do these themes imply about what matters most to you?